



improvement while facing length, back of a length, and short balls channelled outside off stump. In 2025, he got out eight times while facing 64 such deliveries. This year, he could only be dismissed twice off 63 balls. Which is why his average has seen a sharp rise to 72.5 from 9.75 in this regard. As part of dealing with the problem, Samson has started playing more shots behind the square — 35.8 per cent compared to 30.7 per cent earlier.

Then there was the recurring weakness of facing pacers across hard lengths. But the uptick in the last three years has been phenomenal. His strike rate against said bowling was 148.78 in 2024, 130.95 in 2025, and as of writing, a massive 276.31 in 2026. The average has gone from 15.25 to 11.00 and presently stands at 105.00!

"I have been playing this format

for a very long time. Actually, not playing, but looking from the dugout, learning from greats like Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma. I think it's very important to observe and learn what they were doing. I think that really helped me. I have only played maybe 50-60 games, but I've watched around 100 (from the bench). I've seen how the greatest people have finished games and how they change their game according to the situation. This (game vs. West Indies) is one of the greatest days of my life," Samson said. He was right. It was only one of the greatest days, for the greatest ever was yet to come.

In the final, Samson paced his innings adroitly, allowing his partner Abhishek Sharma to play his natural game. He complemented him well, punishing the bowlers for every poor delivery sent his way.

Mitchell Santner, the New Zealand

captain, had depleted four bowlers inside the first four overs, and Lockie Ferguson, the last of them, almost had Samson in a fix when a leading edge sailed towards Mark Chapman at deep backward point. But thankfully, for Samson and India, the fielder could only watch it clatter into the advertisement boards.

When Samson got a boundary past the short fine-leg fielder off the last ball of the fourth over, the Indian pair had already eclipsed the previous highest opening stand in a men's T20 World Cup final of 48 by Kamran Akmal and Shahzaib Hasan in 2009. By the 10th over, it was evident that the spectators were in the middle of witnessing something special. More so, because Samson had just somehow managed to ping a yorker outside off to the fence with mind-boggling ease and pinpoint precision. It was almost as if Samson got James Bond's license to kill after he reached his fifty off 33 balls. And Ferguson bore the brunt, with the pacer conceding two back-to-back sixes and a four in the 12th over.

Samson saved his best for Rachin Ravindra. The left-arm spinner was walloped to three different corners of the park off consecutive deliveries.

"Earlier, he was predictable. He would just go back in the crease — leg stump to leg stump. Today he was all over the shop. He was outside the crease when he hit Henry for a six in the first over itself. The beauty of Sanju is there is brute force, there is a deft touch, there's plenty of class, and he plays cricketing shots. Very little improvisation. He just treats the bowling on merit and has got that power to clear the fence on any ground," Ravi Shastri would later analyse.

When Samson finally mistimed, he walked off to a standing ovation. Naming him the Player of the Tournament had become a mere formality by then.

As all 86,824 people in the stadium paid homage for having unlocked a core memory to be kept safe their entire lives, the writer decided not to get the Superman comic. After all, he had just witnessed one in flesh, blood, and glory.